

Thomas Edison: Inventor and Busy Team Leader

The inventor Thomas Alva Edison had a major effect on the lives of people around the world. Thomas Edison is remembered most for the electric light, his phonograph, and his work with motion pictures.

Edison was born on February 11, 1847, in Milan, Ohio. He was mostly self-taught. His mother taught him reading, writing, and mathematics. He learned from books, and he experimented.

At the age of 10, he experimented with chemicals and electricity. He built a telegraph machine and, at the age of 16, he went to work as a telegraph operator.

He continued his work with electricity, making improved telegraph machines, and he invented an electrical voting machine.

Edison earned enough money from his early inventions to start his own company in 1871. Instead of working alone, he worked with a group of employees on many different projects at one time. They asked the United States government for patents to protect more than one hundred devices or inventions each year. He was an extremely busy man.

In 1913, a popular magazine at the time called Thomas Edison the most useful man in America.

He almost never slept more than four or five hours a night. He usually worked 18 hours each day because he enjoyed what he was doing.

A reporter asked Edison in 1917 which of his many inventions he enjoyed the most. He answered, the phonograph was really the most interesting. The hardest invention to develop, he said, was the electric light. He said that it was the most difficult and the most important. He also invented the modern motion picture film.

In 1928, he received a special medal of honor from the Congress of the United States. Thomas Edison died on January 6, 1931. People worldwide have had easier and more enjoyable lives because of his inventions.

I'm John Russell.

Paul Thompson reported this story for VOA's People in America program. Jill Robbins adapted it for Learning English.

Vocabulary

phonograph - n. เครื่องเล่นแผ่นเสียง

telegraph - n. ระบบโทรเลข

patent - n. สิทธิบัตร

Reading Comprehension Quiz

1. Which of the following is NOT mentioned as something Thomas Edison is most remembered for in the second paragraph?

The electric light

His phonograph

His work with motion pictures

The telephone

2. Where was Thomas Edison born?

New York City, New York

Milan, Ohio

Detroit, Michigan

Menlo Park, New Jersey

3. How did Thomas Edison primarily learn reading, writing, and mathematics?

He attended a formal school.

His father taught him.

His mother taught him.

He hired private tutors.

4. At what age did Thomas Edison begin his experiments with chemicals and electricity?

6

10

14

16

5. What was Edison's profession when he was 16 years old?

An inventor

A student

A telegraph operator

A chemical engineer

6. Which invention, besides improved telegraph machines, did Edison create by continuing his work with electricity?

The electric light

An electrical voting machine

The phonograph

Motion picture film

7. In what year did Thomas Edison start his own company?

1847

1863

1871

1913

8. After starting his company, how did Edison's working style change?

He preferred to work alone on projects.

He worked with a group of employees.

He focused only on a single project at a time.

He stopped inventing and managed the company.

9. How frequently did Edison and his team apply for patents with the United States government?

Once every few years

More than ten devices each year

Over one hundred devices or inventions each year

Only for his most significant inventions

10. When was Thomas Edison referred to as 'the most useful man in America' by a popular magazine?

1871

1913

1917

1928

11. What was Thomas Edison's typical sleeping pattern?

He slept for eight hours every night.

He rarely slept more than four or five hours a night.

He usually slept during the day.

He required very little sleep and often went without it.

12. Why did Edison typically work 18 hours each day?

He was forced to by his company.

He had too many projects to finish.

He enjoyed what he was doing.

He was trying to beat other inventors.

13. According to a 1917 interview, which of his inventions did Edison enjoy the most?

The electric light

The telegraph machine

The phonograph

The motion picture film

14. Which invention did Edison consider the hardest and most difficult to develop?

The phonograph

The electrical voting machine

The modern motion picture film

The electric light

15. What special recognition did Thomas Edison receive from the Congress of the United States in 1928?

The Presidential Medal of Freedom

A lifetime achievement award

A special medal of honor

The Congressional Gold Medal